

THREE SIGNALS YOUR CLIENTS' COMPETITORS ARE ALREADY MOVING ON

What we caught in *specialty coffee* this month

Each month we monitor the specialty & craft beverage space continuously — so your team doesn't have to. Most "trend reports" recycle the same headlines. Below are **three signals with the data behind them**, including one most agencies in this space haven't flagged yet.

01 Matcha quietly became the most profitable thing on the menu

MOVING FAST

This isn't "matcha is popular." The economics flipped. A well-built matcha latte runs an **~83% gross margin** — nearly nine points above a caffè latte. At Blank Street it's now **50% of all orders**; Black Sheep posted a **+227%** iced-category jump after expanding its lineup. And the **\$7-latte price backlash barely touched matcha** — the same customers call \$8–10 "worth it."

Why it matters for your clients: a coffee brand treating matcha as a side SKU is leaving the highest-margin, most price-resilient line on the table. The play is repositioning it as a hero product, not an afterthought.

READY-TO-SEND EMAIL ANGLE

“The drink outselling our espresso (and why our regulars are obsessed)”

02 Co-fermented coffee is splitting the room — and that's the opening

UNDER THE RADAR

This is the one most agencies haven't flagged. Co-ferments — beans fermented with fruit or botanicals for bold "fruit-bomb" profiles — were one of the strongest search-growth signals of early 2026, with Colombia pivoting from washed-coffee tradition to lead the category. But the scene is **openly divided**: purists call it "a shortcut that hides terroir," advocates call it coffee's most exciting frontier.

Why it matters for your clients: a live debate is free attention. A brand that takes a clear stance — for bold experimentation *or* for clean-cup purity — gets a point of view, not just a product. Neutrality is the only losing move.

READY-TO-SEND EMAIL ANGLE

“We tried the most controversial coffee of 2026 so you don't have to”

03 The counter-signal: novelty fatigue is setting in

COUNTER-TREND

While everyone chases the next viral drink, the data points the other way too: Mintel flags **"newstalgia"** as a 2026 driver, and **73% of Gen Z and millennials** now say they prefer **"calm energy" over stimulation**. The mass-market center of gravity is still a clean, reliable cup — not the experimental edge.

Why it matters for your clients: the brands that win aren't only the loudest. There's an under-served audience quietly tired of gimmicks — and a "back to basics, done perfectly" campaign lands hard right now precisely because no one else is running it.

READY-TO-SEND EMAIL ANGLE

“No mushrooms, no glitter — just the best cup we know how to make”

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